

Monday, June 29, 2026

The Day She Answered



After I finished editing the journal website, I joined Discord voice again to watch more Dota 2.

I wasn't really there for the game.

I just liked being around familiar voices.

Outside, the sky started turning gray. It looked like it was going to rain. I found myself quietly enjoying the moment without needing it to mean anything.

Nothing special happened.

Maybe that's exactly why it felt special.



Then she replied.

1:04 PM — Elaine.

She read everything. All seven chapters. And she answered with her own truth.

"Gusto ko din magsabi sayo nang thank you. Kasi you made me feel na ano eh, it's still possible for me, for someone like me, to be loved and to feel special. Na there's still someone na tatanggapin ako whole-heartedly. Na there is someone na who'll love my kids as I do like it's their own."

"I really appreciate what you wrote. It made me realize na you're so good and pure. Yung pagmamahal mo sakin sobrang genuine."

She talked about me and Jeff. She hoped we'd fix things. She said maybe it would take a miracle.

Then she ended with:

"Take care always, Arbs. Hoping din na with your contact gone, another one can come in. I'm here, if you need eyes and ears to talk... maybe one day, we can be good friends."

I thought about what to say.

A week ago, I would have continued the conversation. Found reasons to hold on. Asked questions that didn't need answers.

Instead, I wrote:

"Thank you, Leng 😊"

That's it.

No paragraphs. No convincing. No reopening old wounds. No *"I still love you."*

Just gratitude.

I think that was the quietest victory of the day.



I dozed off again while watching the Dota stream.

2:32 PM — I woke up and laughed.

I think my body is finally collecting the sleep debt from last week. Every time I sit somewhere comfortable — coffee, Dota stream, gloomy weather, full stomach after Pancit Canton, stress level finally dropping — my brain says "Boss, are we safe now?" and shuts down.

Last week I couldn't sleep even though I was exhausted.

This week I can't stop accidentally sleeping because my body finally believes it's allowed to.

That's a huge difference.

I went back to my K-drama.



4:36 PM — Got hungry while watching. Thawed some hotdogs, put them in the air fryer, made rice, ate until I was full, and went right back to the show.

I realized something afterward.

The show isn't even about romance. It's about cooking. And I was genuinely enjoying it. For a whole episode, my mind wasn't thinking about healing, or journals, or breakups. I was just wondering what ridiculous dish the main character was going to cook next.

Maybe that's another kind of progress too.

Not forgetting the past.

But slowly making room for other stories again.



I didn't even notice when the rain stopped.

I was too busy watching my K-drama. When I finally looked outside, the sun had already come back.

Maybe healing works like that too.

It doesn't always announce itself. Sometimes you're just living... and one day you look up and realize the weather changed while you weren't paying attention.

I thought about cooking. My favorite recipes. Bicol Express. My mom's Kaldereta. And Elaine's Tapang Kalabaw.

I think I'll try to make my own version. Not trying to recreate hers. Just creating mine. When I'm sure the taste I'm looking for is there, I'll share it with everyone.

Friends. Family.

And maybe soon, my own family and loved ones.



5:25 PM — It rained again.

Funny enough, I wasn't bothered whether it rained or not. My first thought was, *"At least training will be cooler tonight."*

I laughed after realizing that.

A week ago I would have stared at the rain looking for meaning. Today I was just thinking about the weather.

I've always been the kind of person who tries to see the glass half full.

I don't think that's changing.

If anything... I think I'm finally becoming that person again.



5:45 PM — Episode 5 of The Legend of Kitchen Soldier. The protagonist finally got a leave from the army and went home to see his mother.

It caught me off guard.

I suddenly missed mine.

If only she were still here.

Then another thought quietly followed.

She is.

Every page I've written this week. Every sentence. Every chapter. I've been using something she left me. Writing.

I always knew my mom had a way with words. I never thought I'd borrow that part of her one day.

Maybe this journal isn't just my healing. Maybe it's also one of the many ways she still lives through me.

Mom... I won't stop writing. I'll cherish and practice this gift you quietly passed down to your son.

I may not have been the greatest son.

But you'll always be my greatest mom.



6:43 PM — While watching my K-drama, I got distracted and scrolled Instagram. Ended up messaging someone I hadn't talked to in a long time.

Teacher Dee.

We used to talk online months ago. Just catching up. She asked about life. I told her I got benched at work. I told her I was single again.

Then somehow the conversation found its way to my journal.

I sent her the website.

She asked if it was about my heartbreak.

I laughed.

"About me."

Then she asked if I could teach her how to make one. That made me smile. For the past week I've been writing because I needed somewhere to place all the things I couldn't carry anymore. Today, someone saw it as something worth learning.

She told me she'd read it later.

I told her, *"Sana mafeel mo din yung gusto ko mafeel dyan."*

I wasn't asking for validation. I just wanted another person to feel the same honesty I tried to leave on every page.

Maybe that's what writing really is.

Not collecting compliments.

Collecting understanding.

Before we ended, she said, "*Call tayo later?*"

I realized something. I'm reconnecting with old friends again. Not because I'm trying to fill the space someone left.

Just because I missed talking to them.



9:24 PM — And yeah.

You guessed it.

I fell asleep again.

At this point I think my body is officially collecting every hour of sleep I stole from it last week. I'm not complaining. Last week I couldn't convince myself to sleep. This week, sleep keeps finding me.

Maybe my body finally believes it's safe again.



9:43 PM — Before getting ready for work, I found myself reconnecting with another old friend.

Dewy.

We met back when we were playing Crystal of Atlan. Haven't talked in a while. Sent a simple, "*Hi, kamusta?*"

The reply came almost immediately.

"Huyyyyyyyyyy kuyaaaaaaaaaaaaa!"

It made me smile.

We caught up the way gamers always do. What are you playing now? They're in ROOC. I told her we're mostly waiting for Aion 2. Everyone else has been playing Dota 2. Every conversation between old gaming friends eventually becomes a discussion about the next MMO. Nothing really changes.

And maybe that's comforting.

Before we ended, I sent her an invite back to the Burnik Discord.

"Pag bored ka."

That was it. No deep life talks. No heavy emotions. Just an open door.

I noticed something about myself today. I wasn't looking for someone to replace Elaine. I wasn't looking for someone to fill the silence. I was simply reconnecting. One friend after another. One conversation after another. Almost without realizing it, I was rebuilding my social circle.

Not because I felt lonely.

Because I finally had enough room in my heart to look outside of my own pain again.



10:00 PM — I logged in to work an hour early. Not because there was anything urgent. I just wanted time to prepare before retraining started.

While I was getting everything ready, my phone rang.

Teacher Dee.

We ended up talking over Viber.

I thought about how many people I've reconnected with today. Jalo. Teacher Dee. Dewy. It wasn't planned. I wasn't looking for company. It just happened.

And maybe that's another sign that life is quietly expanding again.

A week ago, almost every conversation in my head somehow found its way back to Elaine. Today, I spent the day talking to different people about completely different things. Games. Websites. Writing. Life.

No one was trying to fix me. No one was giving motivational speeches.

We were simply catching up.

I didn't realize how much I missed that.



11:00 PM — Dee and I finished talking, and I logged in for my retraining.

This exact schedule would have felt heavy a week ago. Tonight, it just felt like work. Nothing dramatic. No anxiety. No overthinking. Just another shift.

1:29 AM — I'm writing this during one of my breaks.

Right now I'm working on lead magnets and social media visuals. It's almost ironic. A week ago, I could barely convince myself to open my laptop. Tonight, I'm designing things again. Learning again. Working again.

Somewhere along the way, I quietly became myself again.

Not the version of me before everything happened.

A newer one.

One that still carries the memories... but no longer lets them carry me.



This morning I opened the journal and wrote about how ordinary the day felt.

Now that I'm looking back at it, maybe it wasn't ordinary after all.

It wasn't dramatic. It wasn't life-changing. But it was full. The kind of full that comes from living an entire day instead of merely surviving one.

I closed one door peacefully this afternoon.

Then, quietly, I opened several others.

Not dramatic doors.

Just little ones.

A conversation with Jalo.

A thank-you to my mom.

Teacher Dee.

Dewy.

Each one reminded me of something important.

My world was never just one person.

It became smaller for a while.

Now it's getting bigger again.

Today's Weight

I forgot to measure it today.

I think I was too busy living.

Songs of Day 6.5



I don't think I'll remember today because of Elaine's message.

I'll remember it because of what happened after.

I thanked her.

And then life kept going.

I watched my K-drama.

Cooked hotdogs.

Fell asleep watching Dota.

Reconnected with old friends.

Logged in to work.

Started creating again.

Somewhere between 1:08 PM and 1:29 AM, something quietly shifted.

Elaine answered.

I answered back.

Then...

life kept going.

Maybe that's what healing looks like.

Not when the pain disappears.

But when your life becomes bigger than the pain.

— *Ralph*.

